

**SHOW OF FANS:** Kissen, Shibani Kashyap and Gaurav Gera (right); Shetty hosting *The Biggest Loser*...

mailed to all media houses (Reshammiya's conceited act, says the tabloid-ready headline).

So how much of the drama is real? Or scored precisely for drums and cymbals? Says Nikhil Alva of Miditech (the people behind *Indian Idol*): "Do you think we can tell judges of such calibre what to say on TV?" Maybe not, but judges are being paid upwards of Rs 1 crore to make an impact, especially in the early rounds, when the audience is not too familiar with the participants. As *Indian Idol 3* judge Chinai puts it: "We are paid for our discomfort." In her case, it's all about preventing herself from bursting into tears when contestants exit and coming to terms with sitting on a panel with Malik, whom she had once accused of sexual harassment. She believes Sony has chosen the judges well: "I am the candy, Javed Akhtar is the master of the game, Anu Malik is cruel to be kind and Udit Narayan is the softie."

As judges go about praising, damning and listening, what of the contestants, who invariably fall to their knees every time they are praised? Their humiliation is complete, a necessary rite of passage in a culture which exalts the desperation to succeed. So whether it is losing weight, acquiring blonde high-lights or wearing bling, it's all a quest for the perfect "package". All sorts of insults must be tolerated in the process, whether it is *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa*'s Mouli Dave being told she can sing only item songs well, or *Indian Idol*'s Suhit Gosain being told that nail paint and heavy metal T-shirts



## THE DEMOGRAPHICS TO DIE FOR

Reality television attracts younger, better-off male viewers

| Shows                          | Viewers in 15-24 age group | SEC A | Male  |
|--------------------------------|----------------------------|-------|-------|
| Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi | 22.10                      | 20.09 | 44.36 |
| Sa Re Ga Ma Pa Challenge 2007  | 26.59                      | 25.25 | 49.04 |
| Kahani Ghar Ghar Kii           | 22.69                      | 18.58 | 45.37 |
| Indian Idol 3                  | 28.82                      | 26.79 | 47.40 |
| Kasautii Zindagii Kay          | 22.98                      | 17.38 | 40.17 |
| Voice of India                 | 23.78                      | 25.68 | 48.35 |

Source: TAM. All figures in per cent. White indicates soaps, red reality shows.

are not enough to become an Idol, or the unfortunately overweight individuals on *The Biggest Loser* Jeetega, who not only have to dance like

Mr Blubber but also decipher host Suniel Shetty's accented English—each sentence serenaded with suspense film sound effects.

Clearly, *gaana* alone is not enough, *ada* is as important. And it's the *ada* that matters. As Khayyam says, it's loud mannerisms and even louder music that seem to be popular with audiences. It's injurious to the ears and the psyche of

youngsters, he says, but this is what music has become: a performance art rather than an art form. "Talent *sunana hi kaafi nahin, dikhana bhi padta hai ab* (talent has to be heard and seen now)," he says. But he too is happily complicit in the new hyper-reality of tv.

If the participants perform, so do the judges. Whether it is Malik chasing a contestant at an audition down the hall when he snatches the invite to Mumbai from him, or Darbar staging a walkout after disagreeing with Khayyam, it's all a bit of *nautanki*. For channels it's the tentpole on which programming gains can be built (evident in the shameless plugging for *Comedy Circus* on *Indian Idol 3*); for news channels, it is potential news stories ("Khayyam *sahib, aapko kaisa lag raha hai?*"); and for viewers it is a weekend retreat from the soaps. Spectacular drama, without the tedium of a convoluted plot. Something no one takes seriously, except the contestants, to whom it matters most. ■